

The South Indian monk Bodhidharma, who exported Mahayana Buddhism to China in the second quarter of the sixth century CE and whose meditation practices laid the foundation of Chinese Chan, which evolved into Zen in Japan. He is always depicted with bulging eyeballs, having cut off his eyelids after falling asleep while meditating. The eyelids are said to have turned into the first tea-leaves. Detail from a painting by a twentieth-century Japanese Zen master.

The legendary element lies in the claim that Bodhidharma brought Tamil martial arts – and, by some accounts, yoga – to China and taught them to the monks at Shaolin as kung fu. Its proponents argue that Bodhidharma introduced a form of Tamil martial arts known as *Kalaripayattu*, closely associated with the Nadars of Travancore. They cite what seem to me to be the very tenuous similarities between Shaolin kung fu and the form of *Kalaripayattu* known as *Varma kali* once widely practised among the Nadars, with its emphasis on sparring with a variety of weapons ranging from swords-and-shields to unarmed grappling with blows aimed at pressure points. The facts are that Shaolin monastery had been established in 495 CE by order of the